the original party lines. The disagreements centred around the candidate selections between the former RNDP members who dominated the party leadership and the former ALD members with longer histories of anti-junta activism (Mratt Kyaw Thu 2015). At the same time, a new political party based on Rakhine ethnicity, the Arakan Patriotic Party, was created with former members of the ALD (Narinjara News 2015).[4] The Rakhine State National Force Party also emerged as a political party based on Rakhine ethnicity, but it was mostly active in southern townships. Despite these external challenges, the ANP managed to remain a single front with an undivided public face during the election campaign, and it was able to resolve internal disagreements at the time of the election (Long 2015a). This unity that the ANP projected strengthened its claim to represent the long-running Rakhine ethno-nationalist agenda.

The Rakhine ethno-nationalist ultimate aspiration is sovereignty over its ethnic nationality and territory, the Arakan or Rakhine State. It is articulated through narratives of past glories of Buddhist kingdoms and the desire to recover the loss of sovereignty after the conquest of Mrauk-U by the Burmese in 1784 (Leider 2008). The narratives of Arakan as the land of the Mahamuni Buddha Image, which was moved to Mandalay by the Burmese conquerors, dominate Rakhine ethno-nationalist discourse (Leider 2009). The descriptions of rich Arakanese kingdoms juxtaposed with the current status of Rakhine State as the second-poorest region in Myanmar creates an inspiration to return the control of abundant natural resources from the Burman-dominated government to local people. The Rakhine nationalists envisage a Rakhine government with independent control over the state's natural resources and directing them for its development. However, Rakhine political parties, whether they are based inside Myanmar or at the border areas, do not explicitly express 'independence' as their main agenda publicly, but the ethno-nationalist ideas of separatist self-determination remain an important aspect of their aspirations (Ware 2015).

The ANP raised the political agenda of winning all the seats and controlling the State Hluttaw, which would result in an ANP chief minister and state government (Eleven Myanmar 2015). With these political tools, the ANP argued, the state development agenda would be in the hands of the Rakhine people and it would take back their rightful share of benefits from the extraction of its natural resources. This message centred on the ethno-nationalist idea of self-determination, though expressed in the context of the State Hluttaw. Moreover, the argument for the control of the state